

cover story AGEING PARENTS

Caring COUNTRIES

CANADA: Take care of your old parents, get a tax rebate. You can also get a six-week compassionate leave.

DENMARK: Do-it-yourself retirement communities, with shared facilities, are all the rage here.

NORWAY: Thousands are taking cures at a growing number of geriatric centres off the Spanish coast, run by Norwegian municipalities.

JAPAN: An array of gadgets. Say, an 'online' kettle that automatically sends e-mails to three recipients when it is switched on. Or a robotic talking doll that tells its elderly owner: "I love you."

US: Need Help? Ask your employer. Companies are adding elder-care benefits to stop absenteeism and work-days lost due to ailing parents.

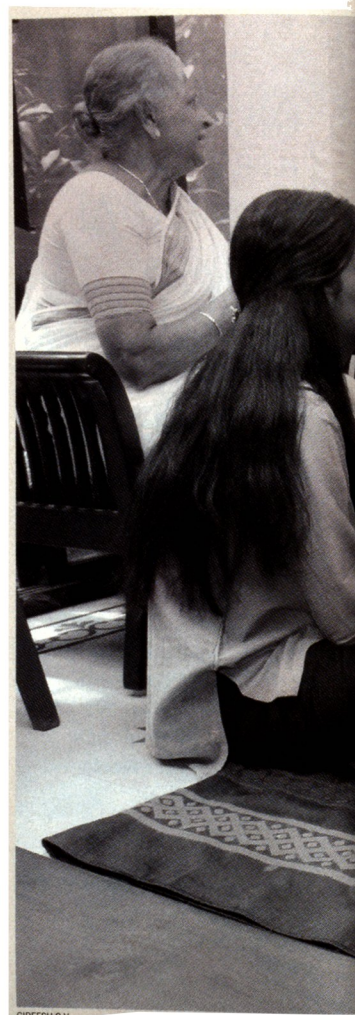
64%
urban elderly
women are fully
dependent.

30%
of seniors seek
medical help
of some sort.

Independence era. For most, this is the first really rough patch in their lives." They belong to a New India, where Gandhian frugality is passé. They shop in malls, patronise private schools and hospitals, and relax in gyms and spas. "They want to be rich, live rich, and they are willing to work hard for it," he adds. Careers—especially, women's—are blooming. As lives become busier, there is less time to look after the home. Ambereen Ali Shah, a PR professional who is also doing her PhD at JNU, agrees: "Whenever we meet up, my friends talk about sibling squabbles and accusations of who's not spending enough time with mom and dad. And we all end up feeling guilty."

It can be rougher for those who are facing the dual pressures of the "sandwich generation"—raising young children and caring for ageing parents. When Geeta Vemuganti began working at the L.V. Prasad Eye Institute in Hyderabad, her biggest worry was if her 10-year-old daughter would manage to braid up her hair for school on her own. "I had to be at work by 7 a.m. most days," she recalls. Today, she heads ophthalmic pathology and her daughter is an independent teenager, but reaching office by seven is still a hassle: "My father-in-law needs me the most in the mornings—to check his blood pressure or pulse rate or just to talk." With growing children, a demanding career, parents-in-law at home, a widowed mother staying close-by and constant travel, her life is more than full. "Sometimes, I feel, I have too many balls to juggle," she smiles. "I keep telling myself, it's payback time. I am where I am because of them all."

Ever since her father passed away in 1987, Monmoyee Basu wanted her mother to find home with her and her bureaucrat husband in Delhi. "Although she didn't really like living by herself," says the 40-something historian with Hansraj College, "my mother didn't have the emotional strength to deal with a life-swap on top of her grief." (Basu may not know, but that decision put her mother in Census 2001 as one of the 50 per cent elderly widows living alone.) Over the years, they have been inviting her to move in with them. "But she misses the familiarity of



her neighbourhood, the quiet pace of her life, and feels isolated here." The daughter manages to spend summer vacations with her mother. Rest of the time, she suffers spikes of anxiety and banks on the telephone to stay tuned to her mom's wellbeing and needs.

Police records reveal, her anxiety is not unfounded. The number of elderly seeking protection in Delhi has jumped three times in the last 18 months. They fear goons, builders and even their own children. The Mumbai police helpline for senior folks gets over 80 calls a day—from medical and travel information, simple advice to friendly chats to ease loneliness. In Hyderabad, constables are doing the rounds with newspaper hawkers each morning to keep a tab on the elderly. In Bangalore and Chennai, the police are busy locating